

CM0859 – MT5009 Type Theory

Martin-Löf's Type Theory

Andrés Sicard-Ramírez

Universidad EAFIT

Semester 2025-2

Preliminaries

Textbook

Mimram ([2000] 2025). Program = Proof.

Other references

Martin-Löf (1975). An Intuitionistic Theory of Types: Predicate Part.

Martin-Löf (1985). Constructive Mathematics and Computer Programming.

Rijke (2022). Introduction to Homotopy Type Theory.

Conventions

- The numbers and page numbers assigned to chapters, examples, exercises, figures, quotes, sections and theorems on these slides correspond to the numbers assigned in the textbook.
- The words “term” and “element” are synonymous. Both words are used interchangeably in these slides.

Introduction

- Martin-Löf Type Theory (MLTT) is also called Constructive Type Theory or Intuitionistic Type Theory.
- MLTT is a foundational system for constructive mathematics.
- MLTT is a dependent type theory.
- MLTT is the basis of some proof assistants.
- There are various versions of MLTT proposed by Martin-Löf and by other.
- MLTT is an open theory.

Dependent Types

- Primitive types

Char, Bool, Nat, Int, ...

- Compound types

$\text{Nat} \rightarrow \text{Bool}$ (non-dependent function type)

$\text{Bool} \times \text{Char}$ (non-dependent product type)

- Types parameterised by types

List Char, List Int, Maybe Bool, Either String Int, ...

- Dependent types: Types parameterised by terms (elements)

Vec Char 2 (vector of characters of length 2)

$\Pi(n : \text{Nat}). \text{Vec Char } n$ (dependent function type)

Inference Rules

Definition

MLTT is a formal system defined by **inference rules** of the form

$$\frac{J_1 \quad \dots \quad J_n}{J} \text{ rule name}$$

where J is the **conclusion**, $J_1, \dots, J_n$ are the **premises** (or **hypotheses**) and $J, J_1, \dots, J_n$ are judgements.

Core Dependent Type Theory

Our presentation of MLTT starts by introducing a core dependent type theory (CDTT) which only contains dependent function types.

Expressions

Definition

Expressions of CDTT are defined by the following grammar:

$e, e' ::= x$	(variable)
$e\ e'$	(application)
$\lambda x^e. e'$	(λ -abstraction)
$\Pi(x : e). e'$	(dependent function type)
Type	(the type of small types)

Expressions

Definition

Expressions of CDTT are defined by the following grammar:

$e, e' ::= x$	(variable)
$e\ e'$	(application)
$\lambda x^e. e'$	(λ -abstraction)
$\Pi(x : e). e'$	(dependent function type)
Type	(the type of small types)

Convention

We shall write t, u and A, B for expressions thought of as terms and as types, respectively.

Expressions

Definition

In the expressions $\lambda x^A.t$ and $\Pi(x : A).B$ the variable x is bounded. The set of **free variables** of an expression e , denoted $\text{FV}(e)$, is recursively defined by:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{FV}(x) &= \{x\}, \\ \text{FV}(t \ u) &= \text{FV}(t) \cup \text{FV}(u), \\ \text{FV}(\lambda x^A.y) &= \text{FV}(A) \cup (\text{FV}(y) - \{x\}), \\ \text{FV}(\Pi(x : A).B) &= \text{FV}(A) \cup (\text{FV}(B) - \{x\}), \\ \text{FV}(\text{Type}) &= \emptyset.\end{aligned}$$

Substitution

Definition

The result of substituting an expression u for every free occurrence of a variable x in an expression e , denoted by $e[x := u]$, is defined recursively by:

$$\begin{aligned}x[x := u] &= u; \\y[x := u] &= y, && \text{if } x \neq y; \\(t \ t')[x := u] &= (t[x := u]) \ (t'[x := u]); \\(\lambda y^A.t)[x := u] &= \lambda y^{A[x:=u]}.t[x := u], && \text{with } y \notin \text{FV}(u) \cup \{x\}; \\(\Pi(y : A).B)[x := u] &= \Pi(y : A[x := u]).B[x := u], && \text{with } y \notin \text{FV}(u) \cup \{x\}; \\\text{Type}[x := u] &= \text{Type}.\end{aligned}$$

Substitution

Definition

The result of substituting an expression u for every free occurrence of a variable x in an expression e , denoted by $e[x := u]$, is defined recursively by:[†]

$$\begin{aligned}x[x := u] &= u; \\y[x := u] &= y, && \text{if } x \neq y; \\(t \ t')[x := u] &= (t[x := u]) \ (t'[x := u]); \\(\lambda y^A. t)[x := u] &= \lambda y^{A[x := u]}. t[x := u], && \text{with } y \notin \text{FV}(u) \cup \{x\}; \\(\Pi(y : A). B)[x := u] &= \Pi(y : A[x := u]). B[x := u], && \text{with } y \notin \text{FV}(u) \cup \{x\}; \\\text{Type}[x := u] &= \text{Type}.\end{aligned}$$

[†]In the textbook the substitution $e[x := u]$ is denoted by $e[u/x]$.

Contexts

Definition

A **context** Γ is finite list of **variable declarations**

$$\Gamma = x_1 : A_1, x_2 : A_2, \dots, x_n : A_n,$$

where the x_i are variables and the A_i are expressions.

Contexts

Definition

A **context** Γ is finite list of **variable declarations**

$$\Gamma = x_1 : A_1, x_2 : A_2, \dots, x_n : A_n,$$

where the x_i are variables and the A_i are expressions.

Observation

Note that the expression A_i can depend of variables $x_1, x_2, \dots, x_{i-1}$.

Contexts

Definition

A **context** Γ is finite list of **variable declarations**

$$\Gamma = x_1 : A_1, x_2 : A_2, \dots, x_n : A_n,$$

where the x_i are variables and the A_i are expressions.

Observation

Note that the expression A_i can depend of variables $x_1, x_2, \dots, x_{i-1}$.

Notation

Sometimes the empty context is written $\emptyset$.

Definitional Equality

Description

Definitional equality (or **judgemental equality** or **conversion**) in MLTT is a notion of equality where two expressions are considered equal if they are syntactically identical or can be transformed into one another through computation (β -equality, η -equality, etc). This relation shall be denoted by ' $\doteq$ '.

Definitional Equality

Description

Definitional equality (or **judgemental equality** or **conversion**) in MLTT is a notion of equality where two expressions are considered equal if they are syntactically identical or can be transformed into one another through computation (β -equality, η -equality, etc). This relation shall be denoted by ' $\doteq$ '.[†]

[†]The textbook denotes the definitional equality by ' $=$ '. We follow the notation in (Rijke 2022).

Definitional Equality

Features

- The definitional equality is an equivalence relation.
- We can substitute types by equal ones.
- We need to add congruence rules for each new type.

Judgements

Definition

There are three **judgements** in CDTT.

- (i) $\vdash \Gamma \text{ ctx}$ (Γ is a **well-formed context**)
- (ii) $\Gamma \vdash t : A$ (t is a expression of **type** A in the context Γ)
- (iii) $\Gamma \vdash t \doteq u : A$ (t and u are **definitionally equal** expressions of type A in context Γ)

Judgements

Definition

There are three **judgements** in CDTT.

- (i) $\vdash \Gamma \text{ ctx}$ (Γ is a **well-formed context**)[†]
- (ii) $\Gamma \vdash t : A$ (t is a expression of **type** A in the context Γ)
- (iii) $\Gamma \vdash t \doteq u : A$ (t and u are **definitionally equal** expressions of type A in context Γ)

[†]In the textbook the contexts are defined using sequents. We use a different notation for avoiding them. The judgement $\Gamma \vdash$ in the textbook is replaced by $\vdash \Gamma \text{ ctx}$.

Types and Terms

Types and terms

*“There is no syntactic distinction between terms and types: both are expressions. The logic will however allow us to distinguish between the two. An expression A for which $\Gamma \vdash A : \text{Type}$ is derivable for some context Γ is called a **type**. An expression t for which $\Gamma \vdash t : A$ is derivable for some context Γ and type A is called a **term**.” (p. 364)*

Rules for Contexts

Definition

The **well-formed contexts** are defined by the following rules:

$$\frac{}{\vdash \emptyset \text{ ctx},} \qquad \frac{\Gamma \vdash A : \text{Type}}{\vdash \Gamma, x : A \text{ ctx.}}$$

Rules for Contexts

Definition

The **well-formed contexts** are defined by the following rules:[†]

$$\frac{}{\vdash \emptyset \text{ ctx},} \qquad \frac{\Gamma \vdash A : \text{Type}}{\vdash \Gamma, x : A \text{ ctx}.}$$

[†]The rules in the textbook uses sequents. We use different rules for avoiding them.

Definitional Equality

Equivalence relation

The definitional equality is a relation of equivalence on terms.

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t : A}{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq t : A,} \text{ refl}$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq u : A}{\Gamma \vdash u \doteq t : A,} \text{ sym}$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq u : A \quad \Gamma \vdash u \doteq v : A}{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq v : A.} \text{ trans}$$

Definitional Equality

Substitution of equal types

We can substitute a type by an equal one.

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t : A \quad \Gamma \vdash A \doteq B : \text{Type}}{\Gamma \vdash t : B,}$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq u : A \quad \Gamma \vdash \Gamma \vdash A \doteq B : \text{Type}}{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq u : A.}$$

Terms and Rules for Type Constructors

Description

For each new type constructor we shall need:

- Three constructions for expressions
 - (1) a constructor for the type,
 - (2) a constructor for the terms of this type,
 - (3) an eliminator for the terms of this type.
- Six inference rules
 - (1) formation: construct a type with the type constructor,
 - (2) introduction: construct a term of the type,
 - (3) elimination: use a term of the type,
 - (4) computation: β -reduces a term of the type,
 - (5) uniqueness: express a uniqueness property of the constructed terms, which corresponds to an η -equivalence rule,
 - (6) congruence: express that definitional equality is compatible with the term constructors.

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Formation rule and associated congruence rule

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash A : \text{Type} \quad \Gamma, x : A \vdash B : \text{Type}}{\Gamma \vdash \Pi(x : A).B : \text{Type},} \quad \Pi F$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Formation rule and associated congruence rule

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash A : \text{Type} \quad \Gamma, x : A \vdash B : \text{Type}}{\Gamma \vdash \Pi(x : A).B : \text{Type},} \Pi F$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash A \doteq A' : \text{Type} \quad \Gamma, x : A \vdash B \doteq B' : \text{Type}}{\Gamma \vdash \Pi(x : A).B \doteq \Pi(x : A').B' : \text{Type}.} \Pi F \doteq$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Introduction rule and associated congruence rule

$$\frac{\Gamma, x : A \vdash t : B}{\Gamma \vdash \lambda x^A. t : \Pi(x : A). B.} \quad \Pi I$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Introduction rule and associated congruence rule

$$\frac{\Gamma, x : A \vdash t : B}{\Gamma \vdash \lambda x^A. t : \Pi(x : A). B.} \Pi I$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash A \doteq A' : \mathbf{Type} \quad \Gamma, x : A \vdash t \doteq t' : B}{\Gamma \vdash \lambda x^A. t \doteq \lambda x^{A'}. t' : \Pi(x : A). B.} \Pi \dot{=}$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Elimination rule and associated congruence rule

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t : \Pi(x : A).B \quad \Gamma \vdash u : A}{\Gamma \vdash t \ u : B [x := u].} \Pi E$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Elimination rule and associated congruence rule

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t : \Pi(x : A).B \quad \Gamma \vdash u : A}{\Gamma \vdash t \ u : B [x := u].} \Pi E$$

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq t' : \Pi(x : A).B \quad \Gamma \vdash u \doteq u' : A}{\Gamma \vdash t \ u \doteq t' \ u' : B [x := u].} \Pi E^{\doteq}$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Computation rule

$$\frac{\Gamma, x : A \vdash t : B \quad \Gamma \vdash u : A}{\Gamma \vdash (\lambda x^A. t) \ u \doteq t [x := u] : B [x := u].} \Pi\beta, \Pi C$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

- Uniqueness rule

$$\frac{\Gamma \vdash t : \Pi(x : A).B}{\Gamma \vdash t \doteq \lambda x^A. t \ x : \Pi(x : A).B.} \Pi\eta, \Pi\mathsf{U}$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

Observations

- The dependent function type $\Pi(x : A).B$ is also denoted
 $\Pi_{(x:A)}B(x)$,
 $(x : A) \rightarrow B(x)$ or
 $(x : A) \rightarrow B$.

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

Observations

- The dependent function type $\Pi(x : A).B$ is also denoted
 $\Pi_{(x:A)}B(x)$,
 $(x : A) \rightarrow B(x)$ or
 $(x : A) \rightarrow B$.
- The non-dependent function type is defined from the dependent function type when the type B does not depend of $x : A$, that is,

$$A \rightarrow B := \Pi(- : A).B.$$

Dependent Function Types (Π -types)

Observations

- The dependent function type $\Pi(x : A).B$ is also denoted
 $\Pi_{(x:A)}B(x)$,
 $(x : A) \rightarrow B(x)$ or
 $(x : A) \rightarrow B$.
- The non-dependent function type is defined from the dependent function type when the type B does not depend of $x : A$, that is,

$$A \rightarrow B := \Pi(- : A).B.$$

- Under the propositions-as-types principle the dependent function type $\Pi(x : A).B$ corresponds to the universal quantifier $(\forall x \in A)B$.

References

-  Per Martin-Löf (1975). An Intuitionistic Theory of Types: Predicate Part. In: Logic Colloquium 1973. Ed. by H. E. Rose and J. C. Shepherdson. Vol. 80. Studies in Logic and the Foundations of Mathematics. North-Holland Publishing Company, pp. 73–118 (cit. on p. 2).
-  Per Martin-Löf (1982). Constructive Mathematics and Computer Programming. In: Logic, Methodology and Philosophy of Science VI (1979). Ed. by L. J. Cohen et al. Vol. 104. Studies in Logic and the Foundations of Mathematics. North-Holland Publishing Company, pp. 153–175. DOI: [10.1016/S0049-237X\(09\)70189-2](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0049-237X(09)70189-2) (cit. on p. 38).
-  Per Martin-Löf (1985). Constructive Mathematics and Computer Programming. In: Mathematical Logic and Programming Languages. Ed. by C. A. R. Hoare and J. C. Shepherdson. Reprinted from (Martin-Löf 1982) with a short discussion added. Prentice/Hall International, pp. 167–184 (cit. on p. 2).
-  Samuel Mimram [2000] (21st Oct. 2025). Program = Proof. Independently published. URL: <https://www.lix.polytechnique.fr/Labo/Samuel.Mimram/publications/> (cit. on p. 2).

References



Egbert Rijke (2022). Introduction to Homotopy Type Theory. Draft version. URL: <https://arxiv.org/abs/2212.11082> (cit. on pp. 2, 16).